

Pulling Out All THE SOPS

The Government targets farmers and the crucial region of Vidarbha in a largesse-driven last mile to the polls

By Aditi Pai

Dig the well before you are thirsty, goes an old Chinese proverb. And Maharashtra's Democratic Front (DF) Government has literally started doing its spadework—digging wells—months before the elections. In this season of sops, the state has announced digging of over 65,000 wells in Vidarbha, a dry region, to generate employment and stop locals from migrating to other areas. Every farmer who digs a well will be paid Rs 1 lakh in a scheme that will cost the exchequer over Rs 1,000 crore. "It is a special scheme to generate instant employment and revenue," says Harshavardhan Patil, minister for cooperation and the Employment Guarantee Scheme. It doesn't matter if they don't strike water in the arid backlands of a drought-prone region. It's just one of the examples of good money chasing bad ideas.

This is not the only scheme the Government has launched ahead of the elections. Rather than promoting industrial growth, the state is using short-term measures to create jobs and win votes. In the last four years, the state's proposals to set up food and textile parks to generate revenue in Vidarbha have remained schemes on paper. Says Mumbai BJP President Vinod Tawde: "The state is facing a deficit of Rs 1,60,000 crore; they don't have funds to implement these

schemes. Nothing will reach more than 5 per cent of the people."

With eight months left for the Assembly polls, the new Cabinet is going all out announcing populist measures. The sops are not just a bait to win votes; if not properly implemented, they often lead to leakages, resulting in the funds being siphoned off by small-time political fixers. "During elections, there is normally a tendency for a culture of 'briefcase politics'. However, in recent times, many parties are wary of this, considering the strict enforcement by the election commission. Therefore, the Government has the added responsibility of ensuring that such packages are monitored by an efficient bureaucracy," says political scientist Venkatesh Kumar.

It's no secret that the new Cabinet's mandate is to drive the Congress-NCP combine back into power. The targets of the largesse are farmers and people of the politically sensitive Vidarbha. The eastern region of Maharashtra sends 11 representatives to Parliament and 66 to the state Assembly. Once a Congress stronghold, the region tilted against the party in the 2004 general elections. In a desperate attempt to win over lost ground, the Government has announced a spate of schemes for the region. Among them is a Rs 4,000-crore special package for eastern Vidarbha, which will provide financial assistance to locals to boost



CHIEF MINISTER CHAVAN WITH HIS DEPUTY CHHAGAN BHUJBAL: (RIGHT) FARMERS QUEUING UP FOR LOAN WAIVER CHEQUES

agriculture. "Until now, the state's influential political class hailed from the western region, so Vidarbha and Marathwada remained less developed. The Government has realised it needs to cater to this section if it wants to come back to power," says Kumar. State politicians also believe that an underlying fear of Vidarbha breaking away from Maharashtra has forced the Government to pay special attention to the region.

With the benefits of the prime minister's package and the Rs 9,000-crore